

Tithonus



POEM TEXT

1 The woods decay, the woods decay and fall,
 2 The vapours weep their burthen to the ground,
 3 Man comes and tills the field and lies beneath,
 4 And after many a summer dies the swan.
 5 Me only cruel immortality
 6 Consumes: I wither slowly in thine arms,
 7 Here at the quiet limit of the world,
 8 A white-hair'd shadow roaming like a dream
 9 The ever-silent spaces of the East,
 10 Far-folded mists, and gleaming halls of morn.

 11 Alas! for this gray shadow, once a man—
 12 So glorious in his beauty and thy choice,
 13 Who madest him thy chosen, that he seem'd
 14 To his great heart none other than a God!
 15 I ask'd thee, 'Give me immortality.'
 16 Then didst thou grant mine asking with a smile,
 17 Like wealthy men, who care not how they give.
 18 But thy strong Hours indignant work'd their wills,
 19 And beat me down and marr'd and wasted me,
 20 And tho' they could not end me, left me maim'd
 21 To dwell in presence of immortal youth,
 22 Immortal age beside immortal youth,
 23 And all I was, in ashes. Can thy love,
 24 Thy beauty, make amends, tho' even now,
 25 Close over us, the silver star, thy guide,
 26 Shines in those tremulous eyes that fill with tears
 27 To hear me? Let me go: take back thy gift:
 28 Why should a man desire in any way
 29 To vary from the kindly race of men
 30 Or pass beyond the goal of ordinance
 31 Where all should pause, as is most meet for all?

 32 A soft air fans the cloud apart; there comes
 33 A glimpse of that dark world where I was born.
 34 Once more the old mysterious glimmer steals
 35 From thy pure brows, and from thy shoulders pure,
 36 And bosom beating with a heart renew'd.
 37 Thy cheek begins to redden thro' the gloom,
 38 Thy sweet eyes brighten slowly close to mine,
 39 Ere yet they blind the stars, and the wild team

40 Which love thee, yearning for thy yoke, arise,
 41 And shake the darkness from their loosen'd manes,
 42 And beat the twilight into flakes of fire.

 43 Lo! ever thus thou growest beautiful
 44 In silence, then before thine answer given
 45 Departest, and thy tears are on my cheek.

 46 Why wilt thou ever scare me with thy tears,
 47 And make me tremble lest a saying learnt,
 48 In days far-off, on that dark earth, be true?
 49 'The Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts.'

 50 Ay me! ay me! with what another heart
 51 In days far-off, and with what other eyes
 52 I used to watch—if I be he that watch'd—
 53 The lucid outline forming round thee; saw
 54 The dim curls kindle into sunny rings;
 55 Changed with thy mystic change, and felt my blood
 56 Glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all
 57 Thy presence and thy portals, while I lay,
 58 Mouth, forehead, eyelids, growing dewy-warm
 59 With kisses balmier than half-opening buds
 60 Of April, and could hear the lips that kiss'd
 61 Whispering I knew not what of wild and sweet,
 62 Like that strange song I heard Apollo sing,
 63 While Ilion like a mist rose into towers.

 64 Yet hold me not for ever in thine East:
 65 How can my nature longer mix with thine?
 66 Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold
 67 Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet
 68 Upon thy glimmering thresholds, when the steam
 69 Floats up from those dim fields about the homes
 70 Of happy men that have the power to die,
 71 And grassy barrows of the happier dead.
 72 Release me, and restore me to the ground;
 73 Thou seest all things, thou wilt see my grave:
 74 Thou wilt renew thy beauty morn by morn;
 75 I earth in earth forget these empty courts,
 76 And thee returning on thy silver wheels.



SUMMARY

The woods rot away; the woods rot away and fall. The mists drizzle their burden of water on the ground. Human beings are born and farm the fields and are buried beneath them; after long lives, swans die. But I am endlessly devoured by immortality: I lie in your arms, Eos, and wither away. Here in the silence of the world's farthest limits, I resemble a white-haired shadow; like a dream, I wander the silent palaces of the East, their mists upon mists, the shining halls of the morning.

Pity me, a shadowy figure who was once a man—a man so gloriously beautiful and so gloriously lucky to be chosen by you that he felt, in his puffed-up heart, that he must be a god himself. I asked you, Eos, to make me immortal. Smiling, you granted my wish, as casually as a wealthy man hands out money. But your servants the Hours, offended, worked away on me: they battered me and spoiled me and withered me. Though they couldn't kill me, they left me disfigured and aged, forced to live alongside you and your immortal youth—age that can't die next to youth that will never grow old. And everything that I once was lay destroyed. Can your love for me, your beauty, make up for this suffering?—even now, as the silver star that guides you hangs right over our heads and reflects in your eyes, which tremble with tears at my words? Please let me die. Take back the gift of immortality. Why should any man want to be set apart from the rest of the gentle human race, or trespass beyond the reasonable limits of human life—the boundary where everyone should stop, as is right and fitting?

A gentle breeze parts the clouds, and I see below me a glimpse of the dark world I came from. Once again I see that old mysterious shimmer on your lovely forehead and on your lovely shoulders, and feel your heart beating with fresh strength. Your cheek starts to blush through the darkness; your beautiful eyes, looking into mine, slowly brighten—though they have not yet grown so bright as they will be when they put out the light of the stars, when the wild band of horses who love you will rise up, eager for you to hitch them to your chariot—when they will shake off the dark of night from their manes and charge through the twilight, fanning its faded coals into the fresh flames of sunrise.

Oh! You always begin shining this way, without speaking, and before you give me any answer, you leave me, your tears still wet on my face.

Why must you always frighten me with your crying? You make me shake, fearing that a saying I heard long ago on earth is true: "Even the gods can't take back their gifts."

Alas, alas: how differently I felt, long ago, and how differently I saw—if that long-lost self was even the same person as me—the shimmering light beginning to gather around you, and your dark hair beginning to catch fire and glow with sunlight. As I watched you make this magical transformation, I changed, too: I

felt my blood glow with the same sunrise warmth that slowly flushed your body and your palace, while I lay there with my mouth, my forehead, my eyelids all warm and dampened with your kisses, sweeter than newly opened spring flowers. I could hear the very lips that kissed me whispering mysterious, wild, sweet words—like the song I once heard Apollo singing above Troy, whose towers rose up as pale and ethereal as mists.

Please don't keep me here forever in your eastern domain. How can my deathless age carry on next to your immortal youth? Your warm, glowing shadows feel cold to me, your rosy light feels cold to me, and my withered feet feel cold as I pass through the shimmering doorways of your palace, while (far below) the morning mists rise from the fields and homes of the lucky people who are able to die, and from the grassy tombs of the even luckier people who are already dead. Let me go; give me back to the earth. You can see everything: you'll see my grave, too. Your beauty will arise afresh over and over, morning by morning. And I, nothing more than dirt in dirt, will forget this hollow palace, and forget the sight of you returning home in your silver-wheeled chariot.



THEMES



OLD AGE AND DEATH

In "Tithonus," Tennyson examines the legendary figure of that same name: a prince of Troy who became the lover of the dawn goddess Eos (a.k.a. Aurora). Eos made Tithonus immortal so that the two could be together forever; sadly, she forgot to specify that he should be immortally *young*. Tithonus thus became impossibly ancient. The miserable Tithonus is this poem's speaker, and his reflections capture the dreadful pain of old age—and the mercy of death. Death, in this poem, is kindly: humanity simply wasn't meant to live forever, and to one day become "earth in earth" is no terrible doom, but a natural relief.

The aged Tithonus feels horribly out of place in the "gleaming halls of morn"—the celestial palaces he shares with his lover Eos. "Marr'd" (or disfigured) and "wasted" (or shrivelled) by the long, merciless passage of time, he's a "shadow" of his youthful self. He can no longer enjoy the pleasures of love in his broken old body. Where once he used to share in Eos's mysterious "change" as she glowed and renewed every morning (like the dawn of which she is the goddess), now he feels alienated from that gorgeous eternal youth; the only embrace he shares with his one-time lover these days is one that leaves his face wet with Eos's guilty tears. His impossible, endless old age, in other words, has robbed him of all life's pleasures, leaving him marooned in a world that can no longer make him happy.

Most mortals escape the pains of their later years the old-fashioned way: by dying. For the immortal Tithonus, however,

that simply isn't an option. Though he begs Eos to "take back [her] gift" and let him die, she doesn't seem able to do so. Tithonus is thus robbed of his only possible release. His longing for death and envy of "those happy men that have the power to die" reminds readers that death, so often imagined as a terror to be fled, is in fact a necessary, natural, even merciful part of human life. Old age, with its frailty and loss, is far more unkind.

Perhaps the poem even suggests that this embrace of death is a kind of wisdom that only comes with age. The arrogant young Tithonus could never have imagined wanting his glorious life to be over. The elderly Tithonus wants nothing more than to be among the "happier dead."

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-76



HUBRIS AND TRANSGRESSION

Like the tragic Greek figure that he is, this poem's Tithonus (the immortal, impossibly ancient lover of the dawn goddess Eos) has a fatal flaw: pride. Smug about being chosen as a goddess's lover, he asks her to make him immortal, and in so doing transgresses a grave boundary, the law that says all mortals must one day die. Now, he suffers the consequences. "Immortal age beside immortal youth," he discovers, is no fun at all. His hubris (or fatal arrogance) destroys him. Enticing as it might seem to go beyond the "goal of ordinance" (that is, the natural limits of human life), this poem suggests that the wise mortal accepts their nature rather than trying to escape it.

In the happier days when Tithonus asked Eos to "give [him] immortality," he remembers, he felt like he was a special person, singled out for greatness. Inflated with the pleasure of being "chosen" by a gorgeous goddess, Tithonus saw himself as better and different than other people—in fact, as "none other than a God!"

But Grecian grandiosity, [famously](#), never leads to good things. Eos responds to Tithonus's hubris with her own careless exercise of power: she grants his wish for immortality as casually as "wealthy men, who care not what they give." But she seems to have forgotten Tithonus's mortal nature as much as he has. It's a real god-mistake to forget to make one's lover immortally *young*, not just immortal; Eos's omission is a reminder that gods, unlike mortals, never need to worry about aging! In short, both Eos and Tithonus ignore what Tithonus really is: an ordinary mortal man, no matter how handsome he is, no matter whom he's dating.

Tithonus's hubristic belief that he should live forever transgresses the bounds not just of his own nature, but of *human* nature. As the sadder, wiser, older Tithonus laments, it's only a fool who wishes to "vary from the kindly race of men": it

is "meet for all" (that is, fitting for everyone) to die one day. Any attempt to go past the place where "all should pause," the poem suggests, invites bitterly [ironic](#) doom.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 11-31



GRIEF AND MEMORY

The story of "Tithonus" can be read, not just as a haunting tale of a wish gone bad, but as an [extended metaphor](#) for the experience of grief. The [juxtaposition](#) of the eternally aging Tithonus with the eternally youthful Eos mirrors the experience of a person mourning a loved one who died too young. The survivor keeps getting older, but the lost one seems trapped in amber, never aging. (This was an experience all too familiar to Tennyson: he drafted this poem shortly after his beloved friend Arthur Henry Hallam died at the age of only 22.) Part of the pain of grief, the poem suggests, is the sense that a happier, more beautiful time remains frozen in one's memory: always present, but just out of reach. Perhaps such memories, no matter how lovely, can even start to feel like a prison.

Every day, the withered Tithonus is confronted with the sight of his beloved Eos lighting up with the sunrise. Like the dawn of which she is the goddess, she shines brighter as night turns into morning: her eyes "brighten," her cheek "redden[s]," and her "bosom beat[s] with a heart renew'd." In other words, she's the very picture of fresh and glowing youth, always as beautiful as she was when Tithonus first loved her. Her "renew[al]" only keeps her the same: she's an eternal vision of "immortal youth." Tithonus, meanwhile, gets older and older, sadder and sadder, wasting away into a tragic "shadow" of his former self.

Eos's youth and beauty thus become an inescapable torment to Tithonus—just as the unchanging memory of dead loved ones might torment those who survive them. Trapped in Eos's "gleaming halls of morn," unable even to escape his suffering through his own death, Tithonus can be read as an image of a mourner paralyzed by changeless images of the person they've lost. Perhaps only the mourner's own death can free them from the prison of memory.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-76



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*The woods decay, the woods decay and fall,
The vapours weep their burthen to the ground,*

*Man comes and tills the field and lies beneath,
And after many a summer dies the swan.
Me only cruel immortality
Consumes:*

"Tithonus" begins with a bird's-eye view of a withering world. The poem's speaker looks out from a great height over vast stretches of space and time. As he watches, "the woods decay and fall"; clouds gather and rain descends; generations of people are born, farm the land, and die; and the long-lived "swan" at last dies, too.

These melancholy visions are seen through the eyes of Tithonus, the legendary figure after whom the poem is titled. In Greek mythology, Tithonus was a Trojan prince who fell in love with Eos, the goddess of the dawn. Wanting to prolong their joy infinitely, Tithonus begged his divine lover to immortalize him. She did so—but forgot to specify that he should be *immortally young*. Tithonus thus became unimaginably old: eternally wasting away, unable to die.

Tithonus's first words suggest that he's already deep into his terrible, endless old age. The weary [epizeuxis](#) of "**the woods decay, the woods decay** and fall" suggests that he's seen forest after forest rise and rot away, frail as flowers, while epochs pass. And the [polysyndeton](#) of "man comes **and** tills the fields **and** lies beneath" captures the one-thing-after-another circle of life ticking ceaselessly away beneath Tithonus's gaze.

His other images suggest that his broad, immortal view of the world has only saddened him. Looking on the heavy "vapours" that gather before rainfall, he [personifies](#) them, imagining that when the rain comes, they mournfully "weep." And his [allusion](#) to the swan, which lives "many a summer" before it dies, raises echoes of a poignant old legend: swans were said to be astonishingly long-lived, and to be silent until the moment of their deaths, when they sang [lovely, unearthly songs](#).

These are visions of *release* as much as sorrow and death. The "vapours weep their burthen to the ground"; in other words, as they cry, a burden falls from them, and they're freed. Readers might imagine those soft clouds melting away not long after their tearful showers. And the swan's death hints at a climactic, transcendent beauty, a moment of glory that comes just before it's all over—and *because* it's all over.

Such releases are not for the immortal Tithonus. In this dramatic monologue (a poem spoken in the voice of a particular character), Tithonus will lament that, while he knows the circle of life and death more intimately than any other human being ever could, he can't participate in it himself. As he puts it, "Me only cruel immortality / Consumes." Death devours everyone else; for him, it's eternal life that, like [Prometheus's vulture](#), gnaws away at him endlessly without ever releasing him into oblivion. The divine gift of immortality has become, for Tithonus, an [ironic](#) and nightmarish curse.

Tennyson tells this haunting tale in [blank verse](#)—that is,

unrhymed [iambic](#) pentameter. That means that each of the poem's lines uses five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm (with occasional variations for flavor). Here's how that sounds in line 1:

The **woods** | **decay**, | the **woods** | **decay** | and **fall**,

This is the grand rhythm of Shakespearean tragedy and Miltonic epic, and it lends Tithonus's story a sorrowful weight.

LINES 6-10

*I wither slowly in thine arms,
Here at the quiet limit of the world,
A white-hair'd shadow roaming like a dream
The ever-silent spaces of the East,
Far-folded mists, and gleaming halls of morn.*

The poem's first lines feel like a lament directed at no one in particular. In line 6, though, Tithonus reveals that he's speaking to someone: Eos herself. "I wither slowly in thine arms," he tells her. The image might put readers in mind of a sickbed where a sad visitor embraces a dying loved one. Here, though, that loved one will never and *can* never die; there's immortal grief and immortal suffering in Tithonus's slow and endless withering.

Readers might wonder what Eos makes of Tithonus's words here. Her only possible answer to the information "I wither slowly in thine arms" would be, "I know." Perhaps there's something the tiniest bit accusatory in Tithonus's tone: he spells out the terrible facts for which Eos is (partly) responsible, and of which Eos is already miserably aware.

Tithonus and Eos rest at the "quiet limit of the world," a place right on the boundary between the mortal and the divine realms. These are the "ever-silent spaces of the East," the "gleaming halls of morn"—the palaces of the morning, where the goddess of the dawn resides, naturally. From these "gleaming halls," Tithonus and Eos look out over an endless stretch of "far-folded mists," one layered on the other like silks. This palace seems to be somewhere high in the sky. All the [imagery](#) around this enchanted place conjures up a soft and shining grandeur: the pale, silent brightness of the earliest morning reigns eternally here.

In this ethereal landscape, Tithonus feels himself to be nothing more than a "white-haired shadow roaming like a dream." That double-barreled moment of [figurative language](#)—the [metaphor](#) of the shadow meeting the [simile](#) of the dream—suggests just how fragile and immaterial Tithonus feels, and how out of tune he is with his gorgeous home. As a "shadow," he's frail and insubstantial, only an outline of what he once was—and he stands in sad, dark contrast with his sunny beloved. As a "dream," he has no solid reality, here or anywhere. He doesn't fit in with his surroundings; he's clearly not a god. But he wouldn't fit in with the mortal world, either. The "quiet limit of the world"

suits him in one way only: like that “limit,” he’s betwixt and between, liminal, not one thing or another.

In his sufferings, perhaps he’s less like a dream, more like a nightmare.

LINES 11-17

*Alas! for this gray shadow, once a man—
So glorious in his beauty and thy choice,
Who madest him thy chosen, that he seem'd
To his great heart none other than a God!
I ask'd thee, 'Give me immortality.'
Then didst thou grant mine asking with a smile,
Like wealthy men, who care not how they give.*

Here, a new [stanza](#) begins with an old idea: Tithonus reiterates that he’s a shadow now, a “gray shadow” of the man he once was. That long-lost man, he remembers, was really something. In his youth, he says, he was “glorious in his beauty,” truly hot stuff—but he felt all the more glorious for being Eos’s “choice.” To be picked out as a goddess’s lover, to be her “chosen” one, is enough to swell any handsome young person’s head. Tithonus’s insistent [polyptoton](#) on “choice” and “chosen” here reflects just how much it mattered to him to be the one Eos wanted.

These lines unearth the seeds of Tithonus’s destruction. Like a true classical hero, he has a tragic flaw: hubris, or fatal arrogance. When Eos chose him to be her lover, he remembers, he felt as if he were “none other than a God!” With a “great heart” puffed up beyond measure, swollen with both love and egotism, the young Tithonus came to believe he was something he was not. And in trying to match his circumstances to his inflated self-image, he brought a curse down upon himself:

*I ask'd thee, 'Give me immortality.'
Then didst thou grant mine asking with a smile,
Like wealthy men, who care not how they give.*

These lines, with their simple but startling [simile](#), reveal both Tithonus’s and Eos’s folly. Tithonus’s mistake is to imagine himself as a god, and to demand the rights and privileges of godhood. Eos’s mistake, likewise, is to forget her lover’s nature, so different from her own. She grants him immortality as carelessly as “wealthy men” might drop a fifty-dollar tip. But in so doing, she seems to forget that humans age! In her own divinity (and as addled with love and lust as Tithonus is), she’s out of touch with the realities of mortal life; perhaps she sees her lover as a god, too. Tithonus asks for “immortality,” and that’s exactly what she gives him—not immortal *youth*, but immortality.

This heady mythological dilemma also captures a humbler human truth. Tithonus and Eos aren’t the first lovers to feel as if their love makes them divine, or to wish their happiness together would never end.

LINES 18-23

*But thy strong Hours indignant work'd their wills,
And beat me down and marr'd and wasted me,
And tho' they could not end me, left me maim'd
To dwell in presence of immortal youth,
Immortal age beside immortal youth,
And all I was, in ashes.*

When Eos granted his wish for immortality, Tithonus remembers, he didn’t have long to relish his triumph. Eos’s servants—the [personified](#) “Hours”—took grave offense at this subversion of the natural order. And, because Eos forgot to give Tithonus immortal youth, those Hours could have their way with him. They behaved like hired goons, roughing Tithonus up:

*But thy strong Hours indignant work'd their wills,
And beat me down and marr'd and wasted me,
And tho' they could not end me, left me maim'd*

These violent lines get at the special [irony](#) of Tithonus’s story. As the goddess of the dawn, Eos is closely related to time: the rising sun, her collaborator, measures out the hours and the days. The hours are *hers* here, “thy strong Hours”; her own servants are her lover’s undoing.

“Maim’d,” “marr’d,” and “wasted,” Tithonus became a wracked and ugly husk of the beautiful young man he once was. He was left:

*To dwell in presence of immortal youth,
Immortal age beside immortal youth,*

His [repetitions](#) in these lines painfully [juxtapose](#) “immortal age” with “immortal youth,” reminding readers of a further irony. Eos’s “immortal youth” reflects the [paradox](#) of sunrise:

- The dawn is unspeakably ancient; it’s older even than the idea of time.
- But every sunrise is also totally new: it begins a fresh day, and [symbolically](#), it’s the “youth” of that day, the very spirit of newness.

Eos’s “immortal youth,” then, is perhaps the most painful thing the withered Tithonus could have to live alongside.

These lines also gesture to the sad story behind this poem:

- Tennyson first drafted “Tithonus” not long after his dear friend Arthur Henry Hallam died at age 22. He would grieve Hallam for the rest of his life, and would revisit and revise this heartbroken poem as a considerably older man.
- The image of “immortal age beside immortal youth” might thus get at one of the strange pains of grief: the dead person remains frozen in amber, forever

the same age, while the mourner gets older and older. [Metaphorically](#), one might read Tithonus as a man imprisoned in his grief, trapped in a memory as painful as it is beautiful, feeling himself withering away within it.

Tithonus, indeed, feels that “all [he] was”—all his youthful beauty and joy and arrogance—now lies “in ashes.” That old metaphor gains fresh meaning here. In a sense, Tithonus has truly been *burnt up* by the merciless course of the sun.

LINES 23-31

*Can thy love,
Thy beauty, make amends, tho' even now,
Close over us, the silver star, thy guide,
Shines in those tremulous eyes that fill with tears
To hear me? Let me go: take back thy gift:
Why should a man desire in any way
To vary from the kindly race of men
Or pass beyond the goal of ordinance
Where all should pause, as is most meet for all?*

Tithonus’s memories of his downfall clearly affect the listening Eos. As Tithonus speaks, he sees her “tremulous eyes [...] fill with tears” at his sad remembrances. But even this moment of tender pity is limited by cruel time. “Close over us,” Tithonus observes, the “silver star” that is Eos’s “guide” is rising; in other words, the morning star is coming up, signaling the moment when Eos will have to leave to bring in the dawn.

In these last moments, while she’s still here and holding him, Tithonus begs her for a mercy he’s clearly asked for many, many times before: “Let me go: take back thy gift.” But apart from her tears, Eos makes no reply.

This passage suggests that this scene is a familiar one: the couple must have had this conversation every morning for centuries. Tithonus knows exactly what the “morning star” reflecting in Eos’s tearful eyes means. And Eos’s helpless silence feels both tragic and ominous. There’s nothing she *can* say to her lover at this point; she must have said it all before. For some reason, it seems to be outside her power to “take back [her] gift” and let him die. All she can do is hold him and weep.

Tithonus doesn’t really seem to expect an answer, either. Rather than waiting for her to speak, he turns away into his own self-accusing thoughts, hopelessly asking why he ever wanted to “vary from the kindly race of men,” to be something more than other humans. Even more significantly, he asks himself why he once was so keen to:

*[...] pass beyond the goal of ordinance
Where all should pause, as is most meet for all [...]*

In other words, looking back, he can only see his desire to

transgress the “goal of ordinance”—the natural limit of human life—as simply not “meet,” not suitable for him or for any human being. Immortality just isn’t meant for mortals, and he knows that now, more acutely than anyone in the world.

Step outside the poem’s frame for a moment, and these lines strike an unusual note. There’s plenty of verse out there in which a poet takes a shot at immortality—whether by making an immortal literary name for themselves or by immortalizing a beloved in verse (or, [more usually, both](#)). By contrast, Tithonus’s desperate wish that he’d stayed within the “goal of ordinance,” rather than trying to stand out from the “kindly race of men,” makes an urgent claim for the value of an ordinary life above a glorious immortal one.

Even the pleasures of *proximity* to immortality and divinity aren’t enough to redeem Tithonus’s eternal old age. “Can thy love, / Thy beauty, make amends [...]?” he asks Eos: in other words, “Can your beauty and your love for me make up for my suffering?” The implication is that these joys, acute though they are, *can’t* “make amends,” not altogether. In fact, Eos’s love and beauty might only compound Tithonus’s pain, leaving him to [writhe over passed joys](#).

LINES 32-36

*A soft air fans the cloud apart; there comes
A glimpse of that dark world where I was born.
Once more the old mysterious glimmer steals
From thy pure brows, and from thy shoulders pure,
And bosom beating with a heart renew'd.*

As Tithonus lies in Eos’s arms with the morning star rising inexorably above them, a change comes: a breeze “fans the cloud apart,” and Tithonus catches “a glimpse of that dark world where I was born,” looking down on the earth far below the “gleaming halls of morn.” At the same moment, Eos begins, mysteriously, to glow.

Her glow is no mystery to Tithonus, of course: it’s something he’s seeing “once more,” and it’s an “old mysterious glimmer,” an altogether familiar sight. To the reader, though, this passage gleams with strange, startling beauty. Take a moment to relish the [imagery](#) and the music of these lines:

*Once more the old mysterious glimmer steals
From thy pure brows, and from thy shoulders pure,
And bosom beating with a heart renew'd.*

The coming of the “mysterious glimmer,” readers soon realize, is the first hint of sunrise. Eos, the dawn’s goddess, is starting to *embody* the dawn, glowing with that strange almost-light that “steals” silently across the horizon a while before the sun appears.

That glimmer emerges from “thy **pure** brows, and from thy shoulders **pure**”—a melodious moment of [anadiplosis](#) that

emphasizes how *perfect* the eternally youthful goddess is. Unmarred and unwasted, she's Tithonus's opposite.

The pulsing /b/ [alliteration](#) in "bosom beating with a heart renew'd," meanwhile, captures the throb of that refreshed heart in sound. It also draws attention to the idea that Eos is not just changeless, but reborn. Just like the dawn of which she is the patroness, she's in some sense "renew'd" every morning, even as she's always just the same.

Eos's transformation, then, is the image of "immortal youth" in contrast with Tithonus's "immortal age." [Paradoxically](#), the dawn is at once eternal and eternally new. With an "old mysterious glimmer" more ancient than the very concept of time, Eos is also reborn, young and "pure," every single morning.

LINES 37-42

*Thy cheek begins to redden thro' the gloom,
Thy sweet eyes brighten slowly close to mine,
Ere yet they blind the stars, and the wild team
Which love thee, yearning for thy yoke, arise,
And shake the darkness from their loosen'd manes,
And beat the twilight into flakes of fire.*

As the sad Tithonus looks on, Eos's dawn transformation continues. It began with just a "mysterious glimmer," like the first hint of pale light on the horizon. Now, her glow gathers warmth and strength:

Thy cheek begins to redden thro' the gloom,
Thy sweet eyes brighten slowly close to mine,
Ere yet they blind the stars, [...]

Readers can perceive the swell of sunrise in the [imagery](#) here. Eos's reddening cheek evokes blushing clouds; her slowly brightening eyes haven't yet "blind[ed] the stars," just as the earliest light of dawn doesn't yet blot the brightest stars out. (Notice, too, how the [anaphora](#) on "thy cheek" and "thy sweet eyes" marks Eos's transformation moment by moment; it's as if Tithonus's eyes are fixed on her changing face.)

Brilliantly, these images of dawn [personified](#) also capture the bright-eyed flush of youthful love. Seeing Eos's blush and her eyes brightening near his, Tithonus also sees what he must have seen when the couple were young together. The image of her eyes "close to [his]," in particular, suggests that Eos's dawn glow echoes the romantic and sexual love they shared when they were *both* young and beautiful. She relives that excitement and pleasure every morning; he can only watch.

Soon, too, she'll leave him. Even now, he observes, Eos's "wild team," the celestial horses who draw her chariot across the sky, are pawing the ground, eager for their mistress to come and harness them.

These horses "love thee," Tithonus tells Eos, perhaps with a hint of wistfulness—or even envy. It's a glorious sight, no doubt,

when those horses' hooves "beat the twilight into flakes of fire," as if they were running across a bed of dormant coals, stirring them back to life. But it's also a sight that Tithonus can't share in. He's not part of this daily renewal, with its animal energy and its fiery splendor. He can only watch it from afar—and wither, and wither.

LINES 43-49

*Lo! ever thus thou growest beautiful
In silence, then before thine answer given
Departest, and thy tears are on my cheek.
Why wilt thou ever scare me with thy tears,
And make me tremble lest a saying learnt,
In days far-off, on that dark earth, be true?
'The Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts.'*

Tithonus has just finished evoking a scene of mysterious and awe-inspiring beauty: Eos's daily embodiment of dawn, the glow that comes over her as she prepares to usher the sunrise in. But it's a sight he's seen a million times, and it's "ever thus," always just this way: Eos glows, renews—then leaves "in silence," without giving any "answer" to Tithonus's pleas for death. All she leaves behind her, he says, are "tears [...]" on my cheek." Their embrace (partly a sad echo of long-ago love, partly the tenderness of the sickbed) never leads anywhere.

Here, Tithonus starts to sound almost peevish about this morning ritual. "Why," he asks Eos, "wilt thou ever scare me with thy tears [...]" Her silent weeping frightens him, understandably. If she has no answer to his begging, he has reason to "tremble" over a "saying" he remembers hearing long, long ago, back in his life on earth: "'The Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts.'"

If this is so, Eos is helpless. Her terrible gift of immortality, granted as casually as if she were flipping Tithonus a quarter, turns out to be irredeemable.

Tithonus's vagueness about when and how he heard that grim saying suggests just how much ground he's lost. He knows he's heard someone say this—sometime—somewhere—in his life back on the "dark earth," a life so distant it might as well been someone else's. His vagueness opens up the possibility that Eos herself told him this, perhaps back when they were first getting to know each other, when neither of them knew how terrible a divine gift would become.

Tennyson frames this dramatic moment in two short [stanzas](#), the briefest in the poem—one three lines long and one four. Appearing at the end of these short, striking stanzas, the fateful words "'The Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts'" stand out, bold and terrible.

As the critic Christopher Ricks points out, those words might also subtly [allude](#) to a passage from John Milton's [Paradise Lost](#). In that great epic poem, which retells the biblical story of the Garden of Eden and the fall of humanity, Milton's narrator has

something similar to say when Eve eats the forbidden fruit from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil (which the deceitful serpent has told her will make her like God). Wishing her transgression undone, that poem's narrator says: "But past who can recall, or done undo? / Not God Omnipotent, nor Fate."

This quiet thematic echo suggests that Tithonus's irreversible curse has something of the Fall in it. Like Eve, Tithonus wished to be something more than he was, to escape his mortal nature; this kind of pride might be *the* fundamental human failing.

LINES 50-57

*Ay me! ay me! with what another heart
In days far-off, and with what other eyes
I used to watch—if I be he that watch'd—
The lucid outline forming round thee; saw
The dim curls kindle into sunny rings;
Changed with thy mystic change, and felt my blood
Glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all
Thy presence and thy portals,*

Flinching from the awful thought that Eos can do nothing to help him, Tithonus turns back to the happy times that got the two of them into this predicament. The "days far-off" of the couple's joyful young love now seem to him so distant that they might as well have happened to a different person. In the mornings, as the "lucid outline" (or clear, glowing halo of light) used to form around Eos's body, "I used to watch—if I be he that watch'd," he says.

And he didn't just watch. As Eos's "dim curls kindle[d] into sunny rings"—that is, as her hair began to shine with sunlight, as if "kindl[ing]" into flame—he shared in her transformation, or felt as if he did. His mirroring [diacope](#) here captures his sense that he was caught up in the swell of dawn:

*Changed with thy mystic change, and felt my blood
Glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all
Thy presence and thy portals, [...]*

He basked, in other words, in Eos's reflected glory—and felt as if he were part of it. (The [internal rhyme](#) between "glow" and "slowly" helps to evoke that sense of Eos's light pervading and "crimson[ing]" all it touched, too.)

Here, Tithonus remembers a common illusion of youth and of youthful love: the sense that it will go on forever. When he was young, these images suggest, he felt as if he, like Eos, was reborn to new delight every morning, and always would be.

LINES 57-63

*while I lay,
Mouth, forehead, eyelids, growing dewy-warm
With kisses balmier than half-opening buds
Of April, and could hear the lips that kiss'd
Whispering I knew not what of wild and sweet,*

*Like that strange song I heard Apollo sing,
While Ilion like a mist rose into towers.*

Tithonus's reminiscences of happy youth now grow even more luxurious. Back in the day, he remembers, Eos didn't weep over his shriveled body in the mornings. Instead, as she embraced him, he felt his:

*Mouth, forehead, eyelids, growing dewy-warm
With kisses balmier than half-opening buds
Of April, [...]*

That [simile](#) suggests that the young couple's kisses felt as delicious as the earliest days of spring. The flowers Tithonus imagines here are still only "half-opening"; they have their whole blossoming lives ahead of them.

And the image of kisses "balmier" even than those buds calls up sensuous bliss. The word "balmy" can suggest warmth (as in "balmy weather"), sweet smells (as in a "balm," a scented oil or incense—see Keats's "[embalmed darkness](#)," full of flowers), and delicate moisture (as in the "fast balm" of amorous sweat that "cement[s]" the lovers' hands in John Donne's "[The Ecstasy](#)"). Think of the damp, tender, scented petals of a sun-warmed crocus, Tithonus suggests—then imagine something like that, but *even lovelier*—and then you'll be close to how delicious those kisses felt.

The young couple's embraces satisfied not just Tithonus's senses of sight and touch and taste and smell, but hearing, too. While Eos kissed him, he remembers, she would whisper to him—words "wild and sweet," spoken in some divine language he couldn't understand. But her voice reminded him, he says, of:

*[...] that strange song I heard Apollo sing,
While Ilion like a mist rose into towers.*

These lines [allude](#) to the legend that the god Apollo (patron of music and the sun, among other things) used an enchanted song to raise the walls of Ilion (a.k.a. Troy—the great city of which Tithonus was a prince). Tithonus's vision of Ilion's [topless towers](#) rising "like a mist" suggests deep awe: it's like something out of a fairy tale, a city soaring up into the air as silent and weightless as fog while a god sings. (The /s/ and /z/ [sibilance](#) in these lines—"strange song," "sing," "mist," "rose," "towers"—evokes an awestruck quiet.)

Eos's voice seems to have worked on Tithonus as the sight of Ilion's birth did; it's an experience of unearthly beauty he can never forget. (Perhaps in more ways than one: readers wouldn't be wrong to hear some sexual subtext in this vision of a god's voice raising towers, especially alongside all those balmy kisses.)

Taken together, this [stanza](#) works like a mini-aubade, a love

poem set at dawn (and often tenderly lamenting the end of a couple's night together). Tithonus's and Eos's mistake, this poignant passage implies, was to believe that an aubade might be made to last forever.

LINES 64-71

*Yet hold me not for ever in thine East:
How can my nature longer mix with thine?
Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold
Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet
Upon thy glimmering thresholds, when the steam
Floats up from those dim fields about the homes
Of happy men that have the power to die,
And grassy barrows of the happier dead.*

Tithonus's bittersweet memories of his and Eos's young love now seem to grow too painful to bear. Tithonus turns away from them and returns to his old plea: that Eos might find some way to let him go, to release him from "[her] East," her immortal world of dawn, into an ordinary human death. "How can my nature longer mix with thine?" he asks her plaintively: he can't bear to be what he is, a creature neither mortal nor immortal, alongside Eos's true divinity.

While for a moment Tithonus seemed to have escaped into his memories, reality returns now, and it feels all the crueler for the brief respite. The relentless [diacope](#) in these lines captures the chill of Tithonus's despair:

*Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold
Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet
Upon thy glimmering thresholds, [...]*

This is another of those moments that might reflect the poem's origins in Tennyson's grief for Hallam. Stranded in the "gleaming halls of morn," watching his lover go through her "mystic change" every day, Tithonus is in some sense trapped in his memories. This is the self-same "rosy" place where he and Eos once felt they were living out an eternal spring morning. But while the surroundings are the same, the joy is gone for good. Like a mourner, then, Tithonus is trapped in memories that he can neither escape nor truly relive. The palace is "cold"; the good times are over, as unforgettable as they are unreachable.

In this dire predicament, the "dark world" Tithonus came from looks like a merciful, restful place. Tithonus seems to glance down at it here, seeing an ordinary day coming in; he watches with longing as the morning "steam / floats up" from the fields, a sight that recasts the grand ethereal beauty of "Ilion" rising "like a mist" into something familiar, homey, rural, and wistful. The "happy men" who live in those ordinary fields, Tithonus says, have the "power to die"—a way of perceiving death that perhaps only an unhappy immortal could reach. Ordinary mortals tend to see death as something that has power over *them*, an

inescapable fate. Tithonus sees it as an *ability*, and a blessing. Preferable even to the lives of those mortal "happy men" are the fates of the "happier dead" beneath their "grassy barrows," or grave mounds. Tithonus's attention to the grass growing over those graves quietly links his longing for death to a wish for a more human relationship with eternity. The bodies beneath those barrows are *becoming* grass, being absorbed back into the world, living not *forever* but *again* and *differently*.

Tithonus wants, in other words, to be part of things again. Readers here might look back to the poem's first lines, where Tithonus watched as "man comes and tills the fields and lies beneath." His great desire now is to be taken back into the steady cycle in which he should by rights participate, alongside the whole "kindly race of men."

LINES 72-76

*Release me, and restore me to the ground;
Thou seest all things, thou wilt see my grave:
Thou wilt renew thy beauty morn by morn;
I earth in earth forget these empty courts,
And thee returning on thy silver wheels.*

For the last time in the poem—though, readers can imagine, not the last time in Tithonus's endless life—Tithonus begs Eos again: "Release me, and restore me to the ground."

These words might take readers back to the beginning of the poem, with its visions of weeping clouds and dying swans. Here as there, the "release" of death also means *relief*, the lifting of a burden.

Tithonus's wish to be "restore[d ...] to the ground" likewise suggests healing as much as return. On the most straightforward level, these words mean that he wants to go back to the dirt from which he came, like the happy dead beneath their "grassy barrows." But the word "restore" also implies that Tithonus might be *renewed* in death, restored by the ground. He wants nothing more than to become "earth in earth," to let the grass grow from his body, to become part of the circle of life again—and thus to be reborn in his own way, transformed.

Here, for the first time, Tithonus seems to imagine what it might be like to be Eos, rather than bemoaning what it's like to be him. "Thou seest all things," he consoles her; she'll thus "see [his] grave," too. Tithonus might worry, then, that Eos won't let him die because she doesn't want to lose him, even in his wretched state. The idea of her watching over his grave seems intended to console them both. But readers know that Eos is truly powerless to help here, not just holding back for fear of grief. The line "the Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts" is too ominously potent, the pressure of the original myth (in which the best Eos can do is to transform Tithonus into a cricket) too strong.

But still, Tithonus begs. His closing words, readers might

imagine, are ones he's been saying every morning for centuries, and will go on saying for centuries more. Once again, his musical [repetitions juxtapose](#) two kinds of eternity:

Thou wilt renew thy beauty **morn by morn**;
I **earth in earth** forget these empty courts,
And thee returning on thy silver wheels.

Tithonus dreams of falling back into the circle of life, becoming "earth in earth"; Eos, he imagines, will go on conducting that cycle from above, "morn by morn." Those [parallel](#) phrasings again summon up the big [paradox](#) of time, its simultaneous eternity and newness. Eos, immortally new, measures and marshals time from the outside. Tithonus wants nothing more than to be back on the inside of time, merging with the [rocks and stones and trees](#) as they roll on below, rising and falling.

The words "earth in earth," as Tennyson himself noted in an annotation to the poem, also [allude](#) to a moment in Dante's *Divine Comedy*, the great epic chronicling Dante's journey through Hell and Purgatory to Paradise:

- In [Paradiso](#) (the final book of the three-volume poem), Dante encounters the soul of St. John the Evangelist in Heaven. St. John takes this opportunity to correct a misapprehension a lot of people hold about his afterlife. Contrary to folk belief, he explains, he didn't ascend to Heaven in his body. Rather, his flesh is "in terra terra"—"in earth, earth."
- Even one of the greatest of the Apostles, then, died and rotted like any other human being. Human greatness, the allusion suggests, emerges from humble mortal bodies, not from hubristic grabs at divinity.

But in these closing lines, Tithonus doesn't just want to escape the "empty courts" of the heavens, humbly die, and fade into the earth. He also wants to "forget" even the gorgeous sight of Eos "returning on [her] silver wheels," coming home to him. The final and perhaps the cruelest blow of immortality is that memory—one of the consolations of old age—becomes, to Tithonus, only a torment.

the gods) granted.

- Alas, Zeus didn't think to make Tithonus immortally young. Tithonus thus aged and withered—and withered, and withered, and withered.
- At last, the grieving Eos transformed him into a grasshopper or a cicada, turning his senile raving into a sad, constant chirp.

The Tithonus of this poem has a subtly different story. Here, Zeus doesn't enter into it. Rather, it's Eos herself who immortalizes her lover, then realizes her mistake—and is apparently powerless to do anything about it. As Tithonus remembers once hearing someone say: "'The Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts.'"

By reshaping the myth along these lines, Tennyson heightens the drama. Eos has reason to feel even more guilty that she's consigned her lover to this awful fate; every morning, Tithonus says, she leaves her "tears [...] on [his] cheek," perhaps in remorse as much as grief. And Tithonus has cause for anger—though he doesn't express much. This poem's Tithonus mostly seems torn between a longing for his lost youth and a longing for sweet death.

The poem also alludes to some of Tennyson's deepest poetic influences:

- Eos's "tremulous eyes" in line 26 echo a line from [John Keats's](#) early poem "[I stood tip-toe upon a little hill](#)"—a line that also describes a moment of tenderness between a god and a human (the love-god Cupid and his mortal beloved Psyche).
- Tithonus's recollection that "the Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts" echoes a similar sentiment in Milton's [Paradise Lost](#), in which the narrator laments Eve's choice to eat the forbidden fruit. "But past who can recall, or done undo? / Not God Omnipotent, nor Fate," Milton's speaker says in Book 9. This subtle allusion underscores Tithonus's fateful pride and hubris. Like Eve, he transgresses, crossing a limit. And like Eve's, his mistake is irreversible.
- Finally, Tithonus's longing to become "earth in earth" alludes to a moment in Dante's [Paradiso](#), where the soul of St. John the Evangelist declares that his body is in fact "in terra terra"—"in earth, earth." He thus contradicts the folk belief that he ascended to heaven with his body intact. (In an annotation to the poem, Tennyson observed that he was thinking of this line when he wrote "Tithonus.") Even St. John himself, then, was fleshly, earthly, mortal. A person of greatness, this allusion suggests, accepts mortality as part of their lot; Tithonus's folly looks especially misguided in light of St. John's wisdom.



POETIC DEVICES

ALLUSION

"Tithonus" [alludes](#) to an episode from classical mythology:

- Tithonus was a legendary prince of Troy who fell in love with Eos (a.k.a. Aurora), goddess of the dawn.
- Wishing to be with her forever, he begged her to make him immortal—a favor that Zeus (the king of

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Lines 11-23:** "Alas! for this gray shadow, once a man— / So glorious in his beauty and thy choice, / Who madest him thy chosen, that he seem'd / To his great heart none other than a God! / I ask'd thee, 'Give me immortality.' / Then didst thou grant mine asking with a smile, / Like wealthy men, who care not how they give. / But thy strong Hours indignant work'd their wills, / And beat me down and marr'd and wasted me, / And tho' they could not end me, left me maim'd / To dwell in presence of immortal youth, / Immortal age beside immortal youth, / And all I was, in ashes."
- **Line 26:** "those tremulous eyes"
- **Line 49:** "The Gods themselves cannot recall their gifts."
- **Line 75:** "I earth in earth forget these empty courts,"

IMAGERY

The poem's [imagery](#) captures Tithonus's poignant predicament. Surrounded by unearthly, immortal, sensuous beauty, he can only long for oblivion.

Tithonus lives at the "quiet limit of the world," a place on the outer edges of the reality that mortals know. Here lie the "gleaming halls of morn," the palaces ruled by Tithonus's beloved Eos, goddess of the dawn. The imagery around these halls is all rosy light and softness: these "ever-silent spaces of the East" are shining and quiet as dawn itself.

The aged Tithonus, among these beauties, feels himself to be nothing more than a "gray shadow," a "white-hair'd" figure tiptoeing through a magical realm, out of place. His beloved, by contrast, is eternally young and eternally renewed. Every morning, he watches as a "lucid outline," a clear nimbus of light, gathers around Eos, and her "dim curls kindle into sunny rings." This goddess, in other words, slowly lights up just as the dawn does, shining with a fresh glow that "redde[n]" and "brighten[s]" as the morning comes.

Besides sensuously capturing the beauty of a slow-gathering dawn, these images of Eos's "mystic change" conjure up a [paradox](#): dawn is both eternal and perpetually new. The vision of the goddess transforming in exactly the same way every morning gets at the desperate sadness of Tithonus's own shadowy predicament. He's immortal, too—but endlessly withering, rather than endlessly renewing. His images of himself as "gray" and "white," pallid and faded, contrast painfully with Eos's brightness.

More painful still, the daily vision of Eos's transformation only reminds Tithonus of what he's lost. When he was young and in love, he recalls, he felt that he, too, "glow[ed] with the glow" that illuminated Eos every morning. Like a lot of young people, in other words, he felt as if he would be young and in love forever. He remembers, too, the love he and Eos shared:

[...] I lay,
Mouth, forehead, eyelids, growing dewy-warm
With kisses balmier than half-opening buds
Of April, [...]

Here, the goddess's caresses feel warm and "dewy" as a morning in early spring, when the flowers are still only "half-opening," their whole blossoming lives ahead of them: another image of eternal renewal that also suggests sheer physical delight.

These pleasures are nothing but a memory now. If the lovers embrace these days, it's only for Eos to drop a guilty tear on Tithonus's cheek. That bitter reality transforms Tithonus's experience of the "gleaming halls of morn":

Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold
Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet
Upon thy glimmering thresholds,

The light and warmth of the lovely dawn can no longer reach Tithonus. Forced to live amongst the "ashes" of his joyful youth, unable to enjoy what once was his deepest delight, Tithonus can only feel this rosy world as "cold." The tactile imagery there suggests just how isolated he feels: he's the only chilly thing in a world of eternal blossoming warmth, beyond the reach of everything he once loved.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-10:** "Here at the quiet limit of the world, / A white-hair'd shadow roaming like a dream / The ever-silent spaces of the East, / Far-folded mists, and gleaming halls of morn."
- **Line 11:** "Alas! for this gray shadow, once a man—"
- **Lines 25-27:** "the silver star, thy guide, / Shines in those tremulous eyes that fill with tears / To hear me?"
- **Lines 32-39:** "A soft air fans the cloud apart; there comes / A glimpse of that dark world where I was born. / Once more the old mysterious glimmer steals / From thy pure brows, and from thy shoulders pure, / And bosom beating with a heart renew'd. / Thy cheek begins to redden thro' the gloom, / Thy sweet eyes brighten slowly close to mine, / Ere yet they blind the stars,"
- **Lines 40-42:** "arise, / And shake the darkness from their loosen'd manes, / And beat the twilight into flakes of fire."
- **Lines 53-63:** "The lucid outline forming round thee; saw / The dim curls kindle into sunny rings; / Changed with thy mystic change, and felt my blood / Glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all / Thy presence and thy portals, while I lay, / Mouth, forehead, eyelids, growing dewy-warm / With kisses balmier than half-opening buds / Of April, and could hear the lips that kiss'd / Whispering I knew not what of wild and sweet, / Like that strange

song I heard Apollo sing, / While Ilion like a mist rose into towers."

- **Lines 66-71:** "Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold / Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet / Upon thy glimmering thresholds, when the steam / Floats up from those dim fields about the homes / Of happy men that have the power to die, / And grassy barrows of the happier dead."

REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) intensify Tithonus's speech, capturing his despair and mirroring the painful, endless march of time.

His first words offer a perfect example:

The woods decay, the woods decay and fall,

This moment of [epizeuxis](#) compresses centuries into a few words. The woods, from Tithonus's eternal point of view, are endlessly decaying and endlessly falling; he's been watching the world for so long that he's seen great forests rise and vanish over and over again. His repetition here feels both weary and poignant. There's nothing he'd like to do so much as "fall" like those woods, but he can only "decay," watching generations of luckier mortal creatures going to their deaths. As he puts it a couple of lines later, "Man comes **and** tills the fields **and** lies beneath"—a moment of [polysyndeton](#) that suggests an endless cycle. Every time another "and" hits, another stage in the circle of life comes along—for everyone but Tithonus himself.

Once upon a time, he recalls, he felt that he was sharing in a happier kind of immortality. When he was young and in love, he used to watch his beloved Eos starting to glow as dawn came on, and felt himself:

Changed with thy mystic change, and felt my blood
Glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all

These lines are full of echoes and mirrorings. "Changed with thy [...] change" and "glow with the glow" reflect each other through [parallelism](#) even as the young Tithonus reflects Eos's "change" and "glow" through internal [diacope](#). Repetitions capture, here, a sense of young love as a blissful attunement: Tithonus and Eos are *matched* in their beauty, youth, and joy.

All that is long over now, of course. As an impossibly ancient man, Tithonus feels the gorgeous "halls of morn" as little more than a joyless icebox:

Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold
Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet
Upon thy glimmering thresholds,

Here, [polyptoton](#) on "coldly" and "cold" insists on Tithonus's

impenetrable numbness. He's *among* those "rosy shadows," but they can't touch him and they can't warm him. All he wants now is to be "earth in earth"—a phrase whose diacope stresses the unity and finality that come with death. Tithonus looks wistfully down to the mortal world, where human beings return to the dirt from which they came.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "The woods decay, the woods decay"
- **Line 3:** "and," "and"
- **Line 12:** "thy choice"
- **Line 13:** "thy chosen"
- **Line 19:** "and," "and"
- **Lines 21-22:** "immortal youth, / Immortal age beside immortal youth,"
- **Lines 23-24:** "thy love, / Thy beauty"
- **Line 31:** "all," "all"
- **Line 35:** "From thy pure brows, and from thy shoulders pure,"
- **Lines 37-38:** "Thy cheek begins to redden thro' the gloom, / Thy sweet eyes brighten slowly close to mine,"
- **Line 41:** "And"
- **Line 42:** "And"
- **Line 45:** "thy tears"
- **Line 46:** "thy tears"
- **Line 50:** "Ay me! ay me!," "with what another heart"
- **Line 51:** "with what other eyes"
- **Line 55:** "Changed with thy mystic change"
- **Line 56:** "Glow with the glow"
- **Line 57:** "Thy presence and thy portals"
- **Line 66:** "Coldly," "cold"
- **Line 67:** "cold"
- **Line 73:** "thou wilt"
- **Line 74:** "Thou wilt"
- **Line 75:** "earth in earth"

JUXTAPOSITION

Tithonus laments that his existence is one of "immortal age beside immortal youth." He gets endlessly older; Eos remains endlessly young. This terrible [juxtaposition](#) is also an image of what it feels like to age in general. Eos, remember, is the goddess of the dawn, a figure representing nature's eternal renewal. In a way, then, Tithonus's predicament resembles the predicament of every living human being: the sun keeps coming up fresh every day, as if reborn, but everyone who lives beneath it keeps getting older. Tithonus's real curse is that he can't end this slow, sad process by dying, the way ordinary mortals do.

The juxtaposition between Tithonus and Eos also evokes the relationship between the living and the dead. Tennyson wrote "Tithonus" not long after his beloved friend Arthur Hallam unexpectedly died at the age of just 22. The poem's image of one lover growing older and older while the other stays the

same age captures how it feels to mourn. Like Eos, Hallam remains (for the grieving poet) frozen in time: die young, and you never get old. Tennyson and Tithonus, meanwhile, are left to look mournfully back on happier days with their changeless beloveds.

Where Juxtaposition appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-6:** "The woods decay, the woods decay and fall, / The vapours weep their burthen to the ground, / Man comes and tills the field and lies beneath, / And after many a summer dies the swan. / Me only cruel immortality / Consumes: I wither slowly in thine arms,"
- **Lines 11-17:** "Alas! for this gray shadow, once a man— / So glorious in his beauty and thy choice, / Who madest him thy chosen, that he seem'd / To his great heart none other than a God! / I ask'd thee, 'Give me immortality.' / Then didst thou grant mine asking with a smile, / Like wealthy men, who care not how they give."
- **Line 22:** "Immortal age beside immortal youth,"
- **Lines 50-63:** "Ay me! ay me! with what another heart / In days far-off, and with what other eyes / I used to watch—if I be he that watch'd— / The lucid outline forming round thee; saw / The dim curls kindle into sunny rings; / Changed with thy mystic change, and felt my blood / Glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all / Thy presence and thy portals, while I lay, / Mouth, forehead, eyelids, growing dewy-warm / With kisses balmier than half-opening buds / Of April, and could hear the lips that kiss'd / Whispering I knew not what of wild and sweet, / Like that strange song I heard Apollo sing, / While Ilion like a mist rose into towers."
- **Lines 64-68:** "Yet hold me not for ever in thine East: / How can my nature longer mix with thine? / Coldly thy rosy shadows bathe me, cold / Are all thy lights, and cold my wrinkled feet / Upon thy glimmering thresholds,"
- **Lines 74-75:** "Thou wilt renew thy beauty morn by morn; / I earth in earth forget these empty courts,"

SIMILE

The poem's [similes](#) convey Tithonus's predicament through vivid images.

The first arrives early in the poem, in the passage where Tithonus explains his terrible situation. Eternally aging, he sees himself now as nothing more than:

A white-hair'd shadow **roaming like a dream**
The ever-silent spaces of the East,

If Tithonus is like a dream, he's insubstantial, unreal, elusive; the simile suggests that he has no place in Eos's world. He's not a young and exuberant god, an immortal lover relishing [more happy, happy love](#) with his immortal beloved. Nor is he a mortal man who can end his painful old age in merciful death. Neither

fully of the divine nor the mortal realm, he can't help feeling like a dream. Or maybe like a nightmare.

When Eos granted Tithonus's wish for immortality, he remembers, she did so:

[...] with a smile,
Like wealthy men, who care not how they give.

In other words, Eos offers Tithonus immortality as casually as a rich person might hand you twenty bucks. She has divine gifts to spare; it costs her nothing to grant Tithonus's huge wish. But that's a problem. This image of divine generosity is also an image of divine carelessness, of a goddess simply not thinking hard enough about what it's like to be a mortal. If Eos had treated this weighty gift more thoughtfully, she might have spared her lover a life of endless decay.

Now, Tithonus is left to wither and remember better times. Looking back, he recalls how Eos used to shower him with:

[...] kisses balmier than half-opening buds
Of April [...]

Eos's kisses, in other words, were as soft and dewy as the budding flowers of early spring. This simile, besides conjuring up deep sensuous pleasure, reminds readers that Eos and Tithonus were both in the spring of their lives, back then—as fresh as just-barely-peeping April flowers. Eos, of course, renews her youth eternally; Tithonus is now lodged in an eternal and ever-deepening winter.

The poem's final simile is a haunting, atmospheric one. Tithonus remembers how once, long ago, he:

[...] heard Apollo sing,
While Ilion like a mist rose into towers.

This passage [alludes](#) to the myth (told by [Ovid](#), among others) that the god Apollo built Ilion—another name for Troy—with his enchanted music. Here, Ilion is at once as grand and as insubstantial as a rising fog. Readers might think of a time they've seen fog from a distance: mists can indeed look like the turrets of a distant city. Besides painting an eerie, vivid picture, this simile reminds readers of what Tithonus has been lamenting all along. Everything on earth—even great Troy, which [famously fell](#) to Greek forces—reveals itself to be as transient and insubstantial as a mist, if you watch it for long enough. Everything, that is, except for the unhappy Tithonus himself.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Line 8:** "A white-hair'd shadow roaming like a dream"
- **Lines 16-17:** "Then didst thou grant mine asking with a

smile, / Like wealthy men, who care not how they give."

- **Lines 59-60:** "kisses balmier than half-opening buds / Of April"
- **Line 63:** "While Ilion like a mist rose into towers."

METAPHOR

The poem's [metaphors](#), like its [similes](#), make abstract pains and beauties tangible.

One of the most persistent metaphors here is a recurring image of flame. When Eos's body begins to light up around dawn, her "dim curls **kindle into sunny rings**," their renewed gold shining as brightly as if her hair had caught fire. The horses who pull her chariot paw the ground, eager to "**beat the twilight into flakes of fire**"—in other words, to light up the dim sky with the sunrise, as if they were stirring last night's coals into fresh flames. These images make a certain kind of sense: as the dawn goddess, Eos collaborates with the fires of the sun, reigniting the day.

But those same fires—which, after all, mark the passing of *time*, the arrival of another day—have the power not only to warm and beautify but to burn things up. Eos lights up afresh every morning; meanwhile, the ancient Tithonus finds "all [he] was" lies "**in ashes**." Fiery time is Eos's element and Tithonus's destruction.

Tithonus also captures the agony of his eternal old age through [personification](#). After he became immortal, he remembers, the passing hours came and beat him up, one by one:

But thy strong Hours indignant work'd their wills,
And beat me down and marr'd and wasted me,
And tho' they could not end me, left me maim'd
To dwell in presence of immortal youth,

Presenting the passing hours as Eos's hired goons, Tithonus gets at the *violence* of aging: the sense that time mercilessly batters everyone who lives to old age. That these personified hours are "indignant" at Tithonus's immortality suggests that they take their work seriously, too. There's no dodging them: they have a job to do, and even Eos isn't going to stop them doing it.

Similarly, a personified "cruel immortality" doesn't just wither Tithonus, it "consumes" him, gnawing away at him endlessly. Particularly hideous in this image is the suggestion that immortality devours Tithonus without doing away with him. Like Prometheus (the mythological figure whose ever-regenerating liver was daily devoured by a vulture), he suffers the impossibly horrible fate of being consumed *forever*.

Another moment of personification feels more poignant. Looking down on the "dark world" where once he lived, Tithonus watches while "the vapours weep their burden to the

ground"—that is, while clouds release their load of rain. These weeping clouds mirror Tithonus's own helpless grief. But their tears are also part of the natural cycle Tithonus has been exiled from. "Decay[ing] and fall[ing]" like everything else on earth, these clouds get to *evaporate* after they've wept.

Tithonus, meanwhile, lives a strange half-life. Twice, he calls himself a "shadow": a "white-hair'd shadow," a "gray shadow." This metaphor casts him as immaterial and frail—and underscores his strange relationship with the sunny, fiery goddess of the dawn. As a shadow, he's just the vague outline of the young man Eos loved, a half-creature *created* by her eternal light.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "The vapours weep their burthen to the ground,"
- **Lines 5-6:** "Me only cruel immortality / Consumes:"
- **Line 8:** "A white-hair'd shadow"
- **Line 11:** "Alas! for this gray shadow, once a man—"
- **Lines 18-21:** "But thy strong Hours indignant work'd their wills, / And beat me down and marr'd and wasted me, / And tho' they could not end me, left me maim'd / To dwell in presence of immortal youth,"
- **Line 23:** "And all I was, in ashes."
- **Line 42:** "beat the twilight into flakes of fire."
- **Lines 53-54:** "saw / The dim curls kindle into sunny rings"



VOCABULARY

Vapours (Line 2) - Mists, thin clouds.

Burthen (Line 2) - Burden.

Tills (Line 3) - Cultivates, farms.

Wither (Line 6) - Shrivels, decay.

Thee, Thou, Thy, Thine (Line 6, Line 12, Line 13, Line 15, Line 16, Line 18, Line 23, Line 24, Line 25, Line 27, Line 35, Line 37, Line 38, Line 40, Line 43, Line 44, Line 45, Line 46, Line 53, Line 55, Line 57, Line 64, Line 65, Line 66, Line 67, Line 68, Line 73, Line 74, Line 76) - Old-fashioned ways of saying "you" or "your":

- "Thee" is the object form of you, as in "I love **you**."
- "Thou" is the subject form of you, as in "**You** can do it."
- "Thy" and "thine" both mean "your"; "thine" gets used before words that start with a vowel, "thy" before words that start with a consonant.

Morn (Line 10, Line 74) - Morning.

Marr'd (Line 19) - A contraction of "marred," meaning "spoiled," "damaged," or "defaced."

Wasted (Line 19) - Shriveled, shrunk, atrophied.

Maim'd (Line 20) - A contraction of "maimed"—that is,

disfigured and incapacitated.

Tremulous (Line 26) - Trembling. (Here, the word suggests that Eos's eyes brim with quivering tears, or that her eyelashes flutter as she tries to blink those tears back.)

The goal of ordinance (Line 30) - The given limits of mortal life.

Meet (Line 31) - Fitting, just, appropriate.

Bosom (Line 36) - Breast, chest.

Thro' (Line 37) - A contraction of "through."

Ere (Line 39) - Before.

The wild team (Line 39) - That is, the horses who pull Eos's chariot.

Yearning for thy yoke (Line 40) - That is, "longing for you to harness them."

Beat the twilight into flakes of fire (Line 42) - That is, fan the [metaphorical](#) coals of twilight into the fresh flames of the rising sun.

Lo! (Line 43) - An exclamation meaning something along the lines of "Look! Behold!"

Lest (Line 47) - In case, in the event that. Tithonus is "trembl[ing] lest" the "saying" he once learned "be true"—in other words, at the thought that the expression he once heard might turn out to be accurate.

Ay me! (Line 50) - A cry of sorrow, rather like "Alas!" or "Oh woe!"

Lucid (Line 53) - Clear, luminous.

The dim curls kindle into sunny rings (Line 54) - That is, "The dark curls of your hair seeming to catch fire as they took on the color of sunlight." Tithonus is describing Aurora lighting up and glowing as the time for sunrise nears.

Ilion (Line 63) - Another name for Troy, the legendary city of which Tithonus was a prince.

Happy (Line 70, Line 71) - "Happy," in these lines, doesn't so much mean "cheerful" as "lucky."

Barrows (Line 71) - Funeral mounds—that is, graves with heaped, rounded piles of earth on top of them.

Tithonus tells his haunting story over the course of 76 lines of [blank verse](#) (that is, unrhymed [iambic](#) pentameter—more on that in the Meter section of this guide). Those lines are divided into seven irregular stanzas, the breaks between them marking shifts in Tithonus's mood or thought.

This is a form inspired by Milton's [Paradise Lost](#) and [Shakespearean tragedy](#). In choosing blank verse, Tennyson gives Tithonus's speech (and the questions it raises about aging and mortality) a melancholy grandeur.

METER

"Tithonus" is written in [blank verse](#)—that is, unrhymed lines of [iambic](#) pentameter. Each line is built from five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, like this:

The woods | decay, | the woods | decay | and fall,

This is the grand rhythm of high tragedy, the same meter in which [Satan spurs on rebel angels](#) and [Hamlet contemplates death](#).

Most long works written in iambic pentameter introduce metrical variations for the sake of emphasis and naturalism. "Tithonus" is no exception. Listen, for instance, to lines 55-56, in which Tithonus recounts a half-agonized, half-awestruck memory of how he used to feel as he watched his beloved Eos glowing brighter and brighter at dawn:

Changed with | thy myst- | ic change, | and felt | my
blood
Glow with | the glow | that slow- | ly crim- | son'd all

Both of these lines start with a [trochee](#) (the opposite foot to an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm). By moving a strong stress to the front of the line, Tennyson makes Tithonus sound urgent and emotional; as the old, old man remembers those long-lost days of shared youth and beauty, his voice gains a new pained energy.

RHYME SCHEME

Written in [blank verse](#), "Tithonus" doesn't use a [rhyme scheme](#). Instead, the poem makes music in other, subtler ways—for instance, through [internal rhyme](#), as in line 56's "glow with the glow that slowly crimson'd all," or through other echoing sounds, as in in lines 8-10:

A white-hair'd shadow roaming like a dream
The ever-silent spaces of the East,
Far-folded mists, and gleaming halls of morn.

The soft /sh/, /s/, and /z/ [sibilance](#) here captures the hush of dawn's "ever-silent" palace and the scuff of Tithonus's limping footsteps, evoking a scene at once peaceful and hauntingly



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Tithonus" is a dramatic monologue: a poem spoken in the voice of a particular character, like a speech in a play. The speaker here is Tithonus himself, a Trojan prince from Greek mythology who fell in love with Eos (a.k.a. Aurora), the goddess of the dawn. Tithonus asks his beloved to make him immortal so he can be with her forever. She grants his wish—but fails to specify that Tithonus should also remain eternally *young*. Tithonus thus lives forever, but gets older and older, more and more withered.

lonely.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is the titular Tithonus himself: an impossibly old immortal begging his lover (the dawn goddess Eos) for death. In becoming immortal, Tithonus feels he's committed a terrible, transgressive act of hubris, attempting to reach beyond the "goal of ordinance" (that is, the appropriate boundaries of human life). Now, he's suffering the consequences.

Readers can understand, though, why he might have found himself in this predicament. Tithonus's lyrical reminiscences of the days when he and his beloved Eos were young and happy together paint a picture of the kind of overflowing bliss one would naturally long to enjoy forever. But where Tithonus once shared his beloved's "mystic change" as she took on her morning "glow," rejoicing in her eternally renewed beauty, now he can only watch from a sad distance, knowing that his unimaginable age has carried him far, far away from that sweet freshness.

In his lamentations over his own hubris, Tithonus is a mirror image of another Tennyson hero: [Ulysses](#), who's just *raring* to surpass human limitations. (Tennyson's "Ulysses" was in turn inspired by [Dante](#), whose Ulysses is [condemned to Hell](#) for his hubristic ambition: though his words are stirring, his goals are as prideful and fatally flawed as the young Tithonus's.) Critics often treat Tennyson's "Tithonus" and "Ulysses" as a matched pair; both poems reflect on transgressions beyond the "goal of ordinance," the natural limits of human life.

Tithonus might also be read as a voice for Tennyson himself. Tennyson first drafted both "Ulysses" and "Tithonus" while grieving his young friend Arthur Henry Hallam. Tithonus's sense of himself as a helplessly aging man still in love with an eternally youthful goddess mirrors Tennyson's struggle. Hallam, here, is the beautiful beloved who will never get any older, frozen in amber as a poignantly young man. Tennyson is the aging lover, looking back on a sweet and vanished time.



SETTING

"Tithonus" is set in the mysterious "gleaming halls of morn"—the celestial palaces where Eos, goddess of the dawn, holds court. High above the earth (which Tithonus can glimpse sometimes when "a soft air fans the cloud apart"), this is a place of "far-folded mists" and subtle, shimmering colors.

It's also a [paradoxical](#) place. Outside of time, as immortal as the sunrise, the palaces of the sunrise are also deeply involved in time—for what marks passing time so clearly as the movement of the sun? While Eos's palace itself never changes, it's a place where the helplessly aging Tithonus can't *escape* change: a

place where Eos's servants, the "strong Hours," hold sway.

Looking down on the world of ordinary people who "have the power to die," sadly watching as his lover glows with fresh dawn light day after day after day, Tithonus is stuck in the middle, able neither to die nor to relish his immortality. He's out of tune both with the immortally beautiful "halls of morn" and the "dim fields" of mortal life.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1809-1892) was one of the most influential and beloved poets of the Victorian era. Poet Laureate to Queen Victoria herself, he became the famous public face of mid-19th-century English poetry.

Tennyson began his poetic career as a student at Cambridge. There he met Arthur Henry Hallam, a friend who would become one of his greatest influences—but not, alas, because of a long and happy life together. Hallam tragically died just before he was to marry Tennyson's sister. Tennyson's overwhelming grief would go on to inspire much of his most powerful verse, "Tithonus" included. He first drafted the poem (under the title "Tithon") in 1833, the year Hallam died. The grandest poetic result of Hallam's death, however, was certainly Tennyson's [In Memoriam](#), a wildly popular book-length [elegy](#) that would fuel a Victorian obsession with grief and mourning.

Like his friends [Robert Browning](#) and [Elizabeth Barrett Browning](#), Tennyson was influenced by the Romantic poets, from whom he inherited a taste for mythology, magic, and melancholy. The death of the dashing [Lord Byron](#) came as a meaningful shock to him as a young boy (though he admired Byron less as he got older), and echoes of [John Keats](#) and [Percy Bysshe Shelley](#) run all through his work. But Tennyson also considered himself part of a longer English poetic lineage that reached back to [Milton](#) and [Shakespeare](#). One can also see a broader European influence in Tennyson's famous "[Ulysses](#)," which retells an episode from Dante's [Inferno](#) (and which is often read as a pendant to this poem).

While Tennyson fell out of style among the early-20th-century modernists (who dismissed his work as too quaint, too pretty, and too conservative), recent scholars have given him more credit, praising his deep sense of mystery and wonder. There's no question that he's an important and influential writer: to this day, poems like "[The Lady of Shalott](#)" are among the best-known and best-loved in the world.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Tennyson wasn't just a popular poet during his time, but a major public figure. As Poet Laureate to Queen Victoria, Tennyson wrote for the British Empire at its peak.

During Victoria's reign, proverbially, the "sun never set on the British Empire": Britain had colonial holdings across the world, and saw itself as the rightful, "civilized" ruler of all the lands it had conquered. Some of Tennyson's own work reflects the intense British patriotism of the time. His "[Charge of the Light Brigade](#)," for instance, is a bombastic celebration of military self-sacrifice. But it's also a tragedy, and reflects another major Victorian preoccupation: mourning.

Queen Victoria's beloved husband Prince Albert died when Tennyson was about a decade into his tenure as Poet Laureate. Victoria went into deep mourning for the rest of her life—and sparked a craze for flamboyant public grief. Victorian mourners would wear black for years, make elaborate wreaths and jewelry out of the hair of the dead, and pose corpses for post-mortem portraits. Tennyson fanned the flames of this obsession with his great [elegy](#) "[In Memoriam](#)," a long poetic commemoration of a beloved friend, dead too young.

Perhaps the Victorian obsession with death and mourning also speaks to the melancholy of a changing 19th-century world. The burgeoning Industrial Revolution ushered in an era of rapid, dirty, and dangerous change. Britain embraced its new economic might—but also mourned disappearing ways of life and a blighted countryside.

to find a wealth of Tennyson resources.

(<https://victorianweb.org/authors/tennyson/index.html>)

- [Portraits of Tennyson](#) — See some images of Tennyson via London's National Portrait Gallery. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/person/mp04454/alfred-tennyson-1st-baron-tennyson>)
- [Tithonus in Art](#) — Learn more about the Tithonus myth and see another artwork inspired by it—this one a painting by Francesco Solimena. (<https://www.getty.edu/art/collection/object/103RG1>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER ALFRED LORD TENNYSON POEMS

- [Break, Break, Break](#)
- [Crossing the Bar](#)
- [Tears, Idle Tears](#)
- [The Brook](#)
- [The Charge of the Light Brigade](#)
- [The Eagle](#)
- [The Kraken](#)
- [The Lady of Shalott](#)
- [Ulysses](#)



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MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about Tennyson's life and work via the British Library. (<https://www.bl.uk/people/alfred-lord-tennyson>)
- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (https://youtu.be/TUKGnq4vknA?si=hLiX37Z-_cbVhK1K)
- [Tennyson at the Victorian Web](#) — Visit the Victorian Web